

Session 32: Views on the Historical Adam

Key Takeaways

- View of Historicity #1 Literary Symbolic: Adam and Eve are purely literary figures in a divinely-inspired story.
- View of Historicity #2 First Ancestor: Adam and Eve are two actual people, specially created by God in precisely the way the text describes, and they are the first ancestors of all humans.
- View of Historicity #3 Archetypal, First Ancestor of All Humanity: Adam and Eve are both the archetypal representatives and the first biological ancestors of all human beings, but the narratives are told in the style and imagery of ancient Hebrew culture.
- View of Historicity #4 Archetypal Representative of All Humanity: Adam and Eve are real archetypal representatives of humanity, but not necessarily the first biological ancestors. The narrative refers to a “real” history through the image-expressive medium of Hebrew literature.

The Historical Adam and Eve Debate

The debates about the historicity of Genesis 1-3 are not simply about how to interpret an ancient text. They are animated by concern to protect and promote the good news about Jesus that presents itself as a solution to the problems introduced in Genesis 1-3. The two most common underlying issues are:

1. Concern for the historical truthfulness of the Bible’s narratives.
2. Concern for the integrity of the good news about Jesus that his life, death, and resurrection brought about a divine rescue from a terrible fate that traps all humanity.

The Historical Truthfulness of the Bible’s Narratives

The modern debates often equate historical truthfulness with a common sense, literal reading of Genesis 1-3 in English. In other words, they don’t always honor the ancient historical and cultural context of the narratives and what the authors mean to communicate in Hebrew.

We should care more about the literary meaning, defined as the meaning intended by the ancient author within their own context. When we do this, we find that a spectrum of views are currently put forward by scholars who all embrace orthodox Christian beliefs and hold the conviction that the Scriptures are the result of divine inspiration.

Four Interpretive Views on the Historical Adam and Eve

View 1: The Literary Symbolic View

In this view, Adam and Eve are purely literary figures in a divinely inspired story meant to prefigure the identity and failure of all the following failure narratives in the Bible. Therefore, the Eden story is intended as a parable prologue to the rest of the biblical story, and Adam and Eve are symbols of the patriarchs and matriarchs of Genesis, and of the Israelites in the promised land.

Representatives of the Literary Symbolic View

- Harlow, Daniel (2010). "After Adam: Reading Genesis in an Age of Evolutionary Science." *Perspectives on Science and Christian Faith*, vol. 62 (p. 179-195).
- Enns, Peter (2021). [*The Evolution of Adam: What the Bible Does and Doesn't Say about Human Origins*](#). Brazos Press.
- Lamoureux, Denis (2008). [*Evolutionary Creation: A Christian Approach to Evolution*](#). Lutterworth Press.
- McKnight, Scot; Venema, Dennis R. (2017). [*Adam and the Genome: Reading Scripture after Genetic Science*](#). Brazos Press.
- Collins, Francis S. (2007). [*The Language of God: A Scientist Presents Evidence for Belief*](#). Free Press.

View 2: The First Ancestor View

In this view, Adam and Eve are two actual people, specially created ("de novo") by God in precisely the way the text describes, and apart from any previous hominid ancestors. They are also the actual first ancestors of all following human beings. Therefore, the Eden narratives do not contain metaphorical imagery or symbolism but are offering a description of what actually happened at the origins of the human race on planet earth.

Representatives of the First Ancestor View

- Barrick, William D. (2013). "The Historical Adam: A Young-Earth Creation View." [*Four Views on the Historical Adam*](#). Zondervan Academic.
- DeYoung, Kevin (2012). [*Ten Reasons To Believe in a Historical Adam*](#). The Gospel Coalition.

View 3: The Archetypal, First Ancestor of All Humanity

In this view, Adam and Eve are both the archetypal representatives and the first biological ancestors of all human beings, but the narratives are told in the style and imagery of ancient Hebrew culture. We should not assume a simple reference between textual imagery and what we might consider historical reality.

Representatives of the Archetypal, First Ancestor of All Humanity View

- Collins, C. John (2011). [*Did Adam and Eve Really Exist?: Who They Were and Why You Should Care*](#). Crossway.
- Stone, William (2014). "Adam and Modern Science." [*Adam, the Fall, and Original Sin: Theological, Biblical, and Scientific Perspectives*](#). Baker Academic.
- Rana, Fazale; Ross, Hugh (2005). [*Who Was Adam? A Creation Model Approach to the Origin of Man*](#). NavPress Publishing Group.

View 4: The Archetypal Representative of All Humanity

In this view, Adam and Eve are real archetypal representatives of humanity, but not necessarily the first biological ancestors. The narratives are told in the ancient Hebrew style that uses imagery and metaphor to communicate truths about history. The narrative refers to a “real” history through an image-expressive medium.

Representatives of the Archetypal Representative of All Humanity View

- Walton, John H. (2015). [*The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2–3 and the Human Origins Debate*](#). IVP Academic: An Imprint of InterVarsity Press.
- Kidner, Derek (2008). [*Genesis \(Tyndale Old Testament Commentary\)*](#). IVP Academic.
- McNall, Joshua (2019). “Where Are You, Adam? Recapitulation and the Human Origins Debate.” [*The Mosaic of Atonement: An Integrated Approach to Christ's Work*](#). Zondervan Academic.

How Do These Views Impact Our Understanding of Jesus?

Does the integrity of the good news about Jesus depend on a first ancestor Adam and Eve or on a representative Adam and Eve? This is a concern for some, so let’s unpack it.

In the New Testament, Jesus’ life, death, and resurrection is portrayed as a divine resolution to the problems of death and sin that began in the Adam and Eve story. Luke presents the baptism and mission of Jesus ([Luke 3:1-22](#); [4:1-44](#)) with a genealogy that traces his lineage back to Adam and God ([Luke 3:23-38](#)). In Romans 5:12-21, Paul presents Jesus as a second Adam.

Romans 5:12-21 NASB*

¹² Therefore, just as **through one human sin entered into the world, and death through sin, and so death spread to all humans, because all sinned ...** ¹³ For until the law, sin was in the world, but sin is not imputed when there is no law. ¹⁴ Nevertheless, **death reigned from Adam** until Moses, even over those who had not sinned in the likeness of **the offense of Adam, who is a pattern of him who was to come.** ¹⁵ But the free gift is not like the transgression. For if by **the transgression of the one** the many died, how much more did the grace of God and the gift by **the grace of the one human, Jesus Christ**, abound to the many. ¹⁶ The gift is not like that which came through **the one who sinned**; for on the one hand, the judgment arose from one transgression resulting in condemnation, but on the other hand, the free gift arose from many transgressions resulting in justification. ¹⁷ For if by the transgression of the one, **death reigned through the one**, how much more will those who receive the abundance of grace and of the gift of righteousness **reign in life through the One, Jesus Christ.** ¹⁸ So then, just as **through one transgression** there resulted condemnation to all humans, even so **through one act of righteousness** there resulted justification of life to all humans. ¹⁹ For just as through the one man’s disobedience the many were made sinners, even so through the obedience of the one the many will be made righteous. ²⁰ The law came in so that the transgression would increase; but where sin increased, grace abounded all the more, ²¹ so that, **just as sin reigned** in death, even so **grace would reign** through righteousness to eternal life through Jesus Christ our Lord.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Corinthians 15:21-22 NASB*

²¹ For since **by a human** came death, **by a human** also came the resurrection of the dead. ²² For as **in Adam** all die, so also **in Christ** all will be made alive.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

It is clear that in Paul's thinking, Jesus provides a solution to a problem that all humanity has—it began with Adam and was intensified by the gift of the Torah to Israel.

In Romans 5:12, Paul's statement that through the sin of one human, death spread to all is capable of multiple interpretations.

- Eden represents an idyllic state of creation pre-fall, where there was no death, disease, or pain of any kind. The first humans spoiled this ideal, perfect state by introducing sin and death.
- Death was a reality outside the garden in the wilderness, but Adam and Eve were chosen out of the realm of non-order and placed in proximity to eternal life. The introduction of "death" in Romans 5:12, then, has to do with humanity's loss of the gift of eternal life that was offered to the first image of God, royal priests. It does not infer that biological death was not present outside the garden before the narrative of Genesis 2:4 and following.

Adam, Original Sin, and Original Guilt

In the early Latin translation of the New Testament, called the *Latin Vulgate* (produced throughout the 4th century A.D.), Romans 5:12 was translated incorrectly.

Romans 5:12 NASB*

... Through one man sin entered into the world, and through sin, death; and in this way, death spread to all humans, **because** (Grk. *eph ho /ἐφ' ᾧ*) everyone sinned ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In the *Latin Vulgate*, the word because was incorrectly translated, resulting in the following translation:

Romans 5:12 DRC

... By one man sin entered into this world and by sin death: and so death passed upon all men, **in whom** all have sinned.

This translation was in the Bible of Augustine of Hippo, a north African Bishop in the 4th century. In his influential book [City of God](#), he formulated the doctrine of original sin. More important was his conclusion that Romans 5:12 implies that all humans who descend from Adam are held accountable for his sin and so inherit biologically from him both original sin (the inclination toward sin) and original guilt (the consequences for his act).

This is the logic behind his theological view that the vast majority of humanity is non-elect, including unbaptized infants who are destined for eternal death (see Augustine of Hippo, [On the Soul and Its Origin](#), ch. 10).

Issues with Augustine's Conclusion

This formulation of original sin and original guilt has questionable biblical foundations. For more details, see Stanley Porter's ["The Pauline Concept of Original Sin"](#) in *Tyndale Bulletin*, vol. 41 (1990) and Oliver Crisp's ["On Original Sin"](#) in *International Journal of Systematic Theology*, vol. 17.2 (2015).

- Paul does not say that all humanity sinned "in Adam." Rather, he says Adam's first sin began a domino effect that led to "everyone sinning" and so bringing the consequences of their own choices upon themselves.
- When Paul says that Adam's sin lead to "condemnation for all" ([Rom. 5:18](#)), this does not necessarily mean that every person is now "condemned" for their distant ancestor's sin. Rather, it seems that Paul is offering a straightforward explanation of the narrative design of Genesis, in which every following generation replays the sin of Adam and Eve in their own way, and so experience divine judgment and grace as a result.

Adam and Eve can still be archetypal representatives for all humanity without being the first biological pair of humans.

- Adam and Eve are portrayed as priests. In the Torah, the priest's representative role does not depend on their biological priority over those whom they represent. Rather, it is their shared humanity that qualifies them (as in the argument of [Hebrews 1:1-8:13](#)).
- Jesus is clearly portrayed as humanity's high priest, even over those who do not descend from him (he didn't marry!). If Jesus' right standing before God can be attributed to us apart from biological descent, then our covenant relationship with God stands independent of ancestry. Why should Adam's act have relevance only for his biological descendants if, in fact, he was appointed as a representative priest?
- Priests are selected from a larger group to represent the many. If this is the model on which the Adam and Eve story is formed, then it explains the sudden presence of other humans outside of Eden (Cain's wife, the inhabitants of his city), and perhaps before Eden (the humanity of Genesis 1).

"If other homonins lived before Adam, then one must account for what makes Adam distinct. The divine image is an excellent candidate ... This creature is patterned after the one who is the true image of the invisible God ... [Resulting in] a relationship that never before existed ... a vocation of authentic moral responsibility that allowed Adam to transcend animal instinct in order to mirror (or fail to mirror) the image of [God] ... If these image bearers were indeed selected from the mass of (nonhuman) homonins, then the parallels between Adam and Israel are deepened ... Just as God chose Israel from the rest of mankind for a strange, special, demanding vocation, so perhaps what Genesis is telling us is that God chose one pair from the rest of early hominids for a similar vocation. In this way, the election of Adam bears a relation to the vocation of Israel, just as the bestowal of the image upon Adam's 'collaterals' bears a resemblance to the New Testament inclusion within God's great family."

McNall, Joshua (2019). *The Mosaic of Atonement: An Integrated Approach to Christ's Work*. Zondervan Academic.

Reflection Question

Tim outlined four different ways to answer the historicity question: literary symbolic, first ancestor, archetypal first ancestor, and archetypal non-first ancestor. Briefly summarize each view.